눈치로 읽기: 이 말, 진짜 뜻은 뭐예요?

Learners read common Korean hint expressions and find the real request or refusal behind the words.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, learners can tell what a speaker really wants from common Korean hints and use 눈치가 빠르다, 눈치가 없다, and 눈치를 보다 correctly.

1 WHAT IS 눈치?

눈치 (nunchi) means sensing what someone wants without being told. Koreans often hint instead of asking directly, especially with elders, bosses, and people they don't know well. A direct "no" or "close the window" can sound too strong.

2 HINTS AND THEIR REAL MEANING

1	**좀 춥지 않아요?** (Isn't it a bit cold?)	Often a soft request to close the window or turn up the heat. 예: 좀 춥지 않아요? 창문이 열려 있네요.
2	**시간이 벌써 이렇게 됐네요** (Look at the time)	The speaker wants to finish the meeting or leave. 예: 어머, 시간이 벌써 이렇게 됐네요.
3	**좀 어려울 것 같아요** (That might be hard)	A polite way to say no. 예: 죄송한데 이번 주는 좀 어려울 것 같아요.
4	**-아서요/-어서요** ((giving only a reason))	When someone gives only a reason and stops, it usually means no. 예: 가고 싶은데 그날은 약속이 있어서요.
5	**생각해 볼게요** (I'll think about it)	Often a gentle no, especially to a seller. 예: 가격이 좀 비싸네요. 생각해 볼게요.
6	**혹시 시간 괜찮으세요?** (Do you have a minute?)	Tells you that a request is coming. 예: 저, 혹시 잠깐 시간 괜찮으세요?
7	**눈치가 빠르다** (quick to sense things)	Describes someone who understands without being told. 예: 수진 씨는 눈치가 빨라서 말 안 해도 다 알아요.
8	**눈치가 없다** (can't read the room)	Describes someone who misses hints. 예: 그 사람은 눈치가 없어서 회의 때 계속 농담을 해요.
9	**눈치를 보다** (watch others' reactions)	To be careful about what others think before you act. 예: 다들 일하고 있어서 퇴근할 때 눈치를 봤어요.

3 HOW TO READ A HINT

1. **말 듣기** (Listen to the words) →
2. **상황 보기** (Notice the time, place, and person) →
3. **진짜 뜻 찾기** (Ask: what does this person want?) →
4. **행동이나 부드러운 말로 답하기** (Reply with an action or a soft answer)

The same words can be a real question in another situation, so always check the context.

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4 YOUR TURN

FIND THE REAL MEANING
Read each situation, think about what the speaker really wants, and then choose or write the answer.

1 Choose the real meaning. At 11 p.m. at a friend's home, your friend says:
"나 내일 아침에 일찍 나가야 되는데…"
(a) Please stay longer.
(b) It is time for you to go home.

2 You invited a friend to meet on Saturday. Is each reply Yes or No?
①토요일은 제가 좀 바빠서요.
②좋아요, 몇 시에 만날까요?
③가고 싶은데 그날은 집에 일이 좀 있어서요.

3 Choose what the coworker really wants. Your coworker has been staring at an English document with a worried face for a long time. Then your coworker holds the document out toward you and says:
"혹시 영어로 된 서류 읽을 줄 아세요?"
(a) They are just curious about your English.
(b) They want you to help them read a document.

4 Choose the reply that shows good 눈치. A grandmother says:
"아이고, 이 가방이 왜 이렇게 무겁지?" ⓐ 네, 정말 무거워 보여요. ⓑ 제가 들어 드릴게요.

5 Fill in the blank with 빨라요, 없어요, or 눈치를:
①말을 안 했는데 지훈 씨가 먼저 물을 가져다줬어요. 지훈 씨는 눈치가 ____.
②새 회사라서 점심 메뉴도 선배들 ____ 보면서 골라요.
③친구가 계속 시계를 보는데 민호는 계속 이야기했어요. 민호는 눈치가 ____.

✓ ANSWERS

1) (b) It is time for you to go home.
2) ① No ② Yes ③ No
3) (b) They want you to help them read a document.
4) ⓑ 제가 들어 드릴게요.
5) ① 빨라요 ② 눈치를 ③ 없어요

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